

THE QUIET CRAFT

A Working Writer's Notebook — Reader's Circle Exclusive

BY JAMES MULHERN

A NOTE BEFORE YOU BEGIN

This is not a course. It is a handful of working notes I keep returning to — at my own desk, and in thirty years of classrooms — distilled here for readers who have joined the Circle. Nothing in these pages appears anywhere else on my site. Treat it as a notebook you can argue with.

I. BEGIN WITH THE OBJECT, NOT THE FEELING

Grief, joy, and shame are not subjects a story can hold directly — they slip through the hand that reaches for them. What a story can hold is a chopped piano. A spoon of red jello. A housedress with a pattern of tiny roses on it.

When I sit down to draft a scene and feel the emotion arriving too easily — when a character is simply "sad" or "furious" on the page — I stop and ask what object is in the room. Not decoration. The one object the character would reach for, avoid, or fail to notice. Let the object carry the freight. The feeling will arrive in the reader without ever being named, and it will arrive heavier for the discretion.

A NOTE FOR THE DESK

Take a scene you're avoiding because the emotion feels too large to write directly. Find the one physical object in that room. Write the scene using only what the object does — who touches it, who won't, where it ends up — and cut every sentence that states the feeling outright.

II. THE BODY IS NOT AN OBSTACLE TO THE SACRED

A character's limp, gout, stutter, or drinking is not something a story has to write around on its way to a more dignified truth. Examined closely, the failing body is often the ground the truth grows from. I do not let my characters flinch from the body in front of them, and I try not to either.

Sentimentality, in my experience, begins exactly at the moment a writer looks away from the actual body — softening a death, tidying a decline, letting a euphemism stand in for a diaper or a tremor. Compassion is not softness. Compassion is the discipline of continuing to look.

A NOTE FOR THE DESK

Reread your current draft and find every place you've used a euphemism for something physical — for illness, age, appetite, want. Replace each one with the plain, unflinching word. Notice what the sentence gains.

III. WRITE THE ORDINARY DETAIL TWICE AS LONG AS YOU THINK IT DESERVES

A chipmunk on the patio. Suntan oil. Kitchen light at six in the morning. These are the details most drafts rush past on the way to what the writer assumes is the "real" scene. I have come to believe the opposite: the ordinary detail, given more time than it seems to deserve, is where the reader's trust in you as a narrator is built. Rush the ordinary and the extraordinary — the death, the confession, the reunion — will land on ground the reader hasn't been prepared to stand on.

A NOTE FOR THE DESK

Choose the least important object in your current scene — a spoon, a doorframe, a bathrobe. Write four sentences about it that a first draft would have compressed into one. Then decide, deliberately, how many of those four survive.

IV. REVISE THE WAY YOU'D FORGIVE SOMEONE

I was raised to understand forgiveness less as a principle to announce than an obligation to live, mostly by watching people do it badly and well in the same week. Revision, I've come to think, works the same way. You do not revise a sentence by attacking it for what it failed to be. You revise it by sitting with it long enough to see what it was actually trying to do, and helping it do that one thing more precisely.

Cut the sentence that is only there to impress you. Keep the plain sentence that is quietly doing its job. A manuscript, like a family, is improved far more by patient attention than by a single decisive verdict.

A NOTE FOR THE DESK

Take one paragraph you've rewritten more than three times without satisfaction. Instead of rewriting it again, write one sentence describing what that paragraph is trying to do. Then revise toward that sentence alone.

V. READ THE LINE ALOUD BEFORE YOU TRUST IT

Every line I keep has been said aloud, usually more than once, often to an empty room. The ear catches what the eye forgives — the extra clause, the word repeated four lines back, the rhythm that goes slack right where the sentence needed to tighten. This is not a superstition. It is the fastest edit available to any writer, and the one most often skipped.

A NOTE FOR THE DESK

Read your opening page aloud, without stopping to fix anything. Mark only the places where your own voice stumbled. Those are your first true edits — before a single outside reader ever sees the page.

If one of these notes was useful to you, I'd be glad to hear which — reply to any Reader's Circle email, or write to me directly. Thank you for reading, and for joining the Circle.

— JAMES MULHERN

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